

What's going on in America?

Quincy Morgan / @quincylvania

waysidemapping.org

*Wayside
Mapping* 



Are we okay?





Are we okay?
No, but let's focus on OpenStreetMap



“I thought this was State of
the Map *Europe*...”



“I thought this was of
the Map *Europe*





CC BY SA 2 Neil Owen

Often:

America and Europe are two continents divided by a common map



Often:

America and Europe are two continents divided by a common map

But:

Stronger understanding

=

Stronger OpenStreetMap

US-based companies relying on OpenStreetMap



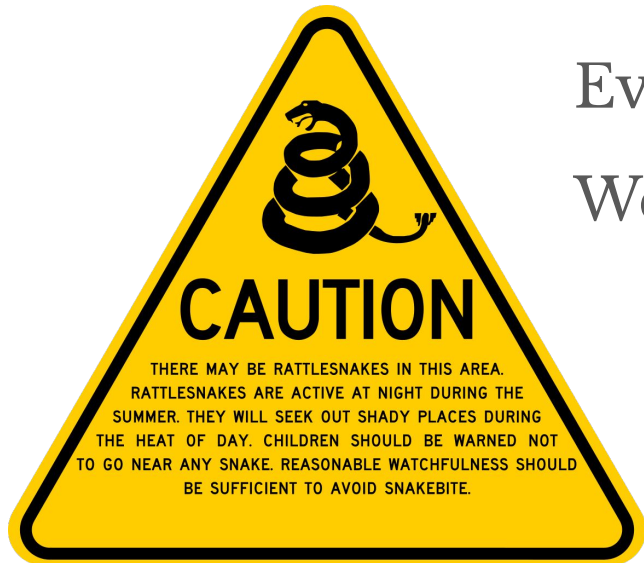
Caveats to this talk

I'm using broad generalizations

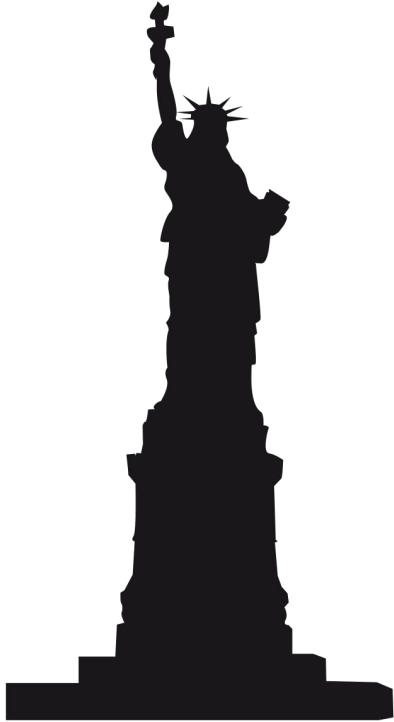
“America” and “Europe” are fuzzy terms

Every example has a counterexample

We are more similar than we are different



What makes OpenStreetMap different in the US?
Why are we like this?



What makes OpenStreetMap different in the US?

Why are we like this?

1. Late start



50 states
12 years
5 minutes

Minh Nguyễn
State of the Map 2019

Playground map by unknown artist, PD
Seen in Ohio Statewide Imagery Program, PD

[CC BY SA 4 Minh Nguyễn](https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/)

<https://2019.stateofthemap.org/sessions/BBRMPZ/>

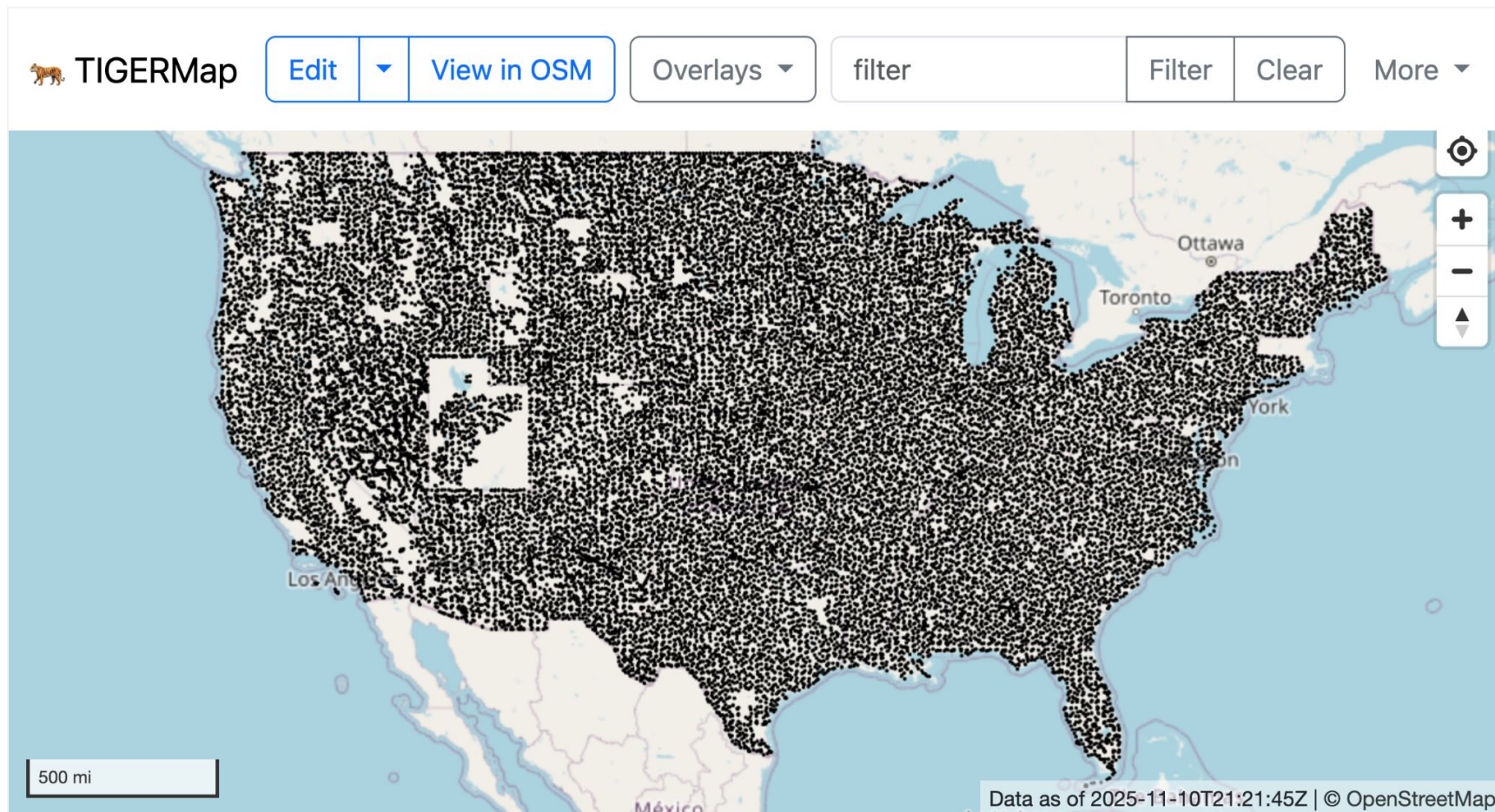


TIGER import (of US roads): 2007–2008

Arguable start of OSM in the US



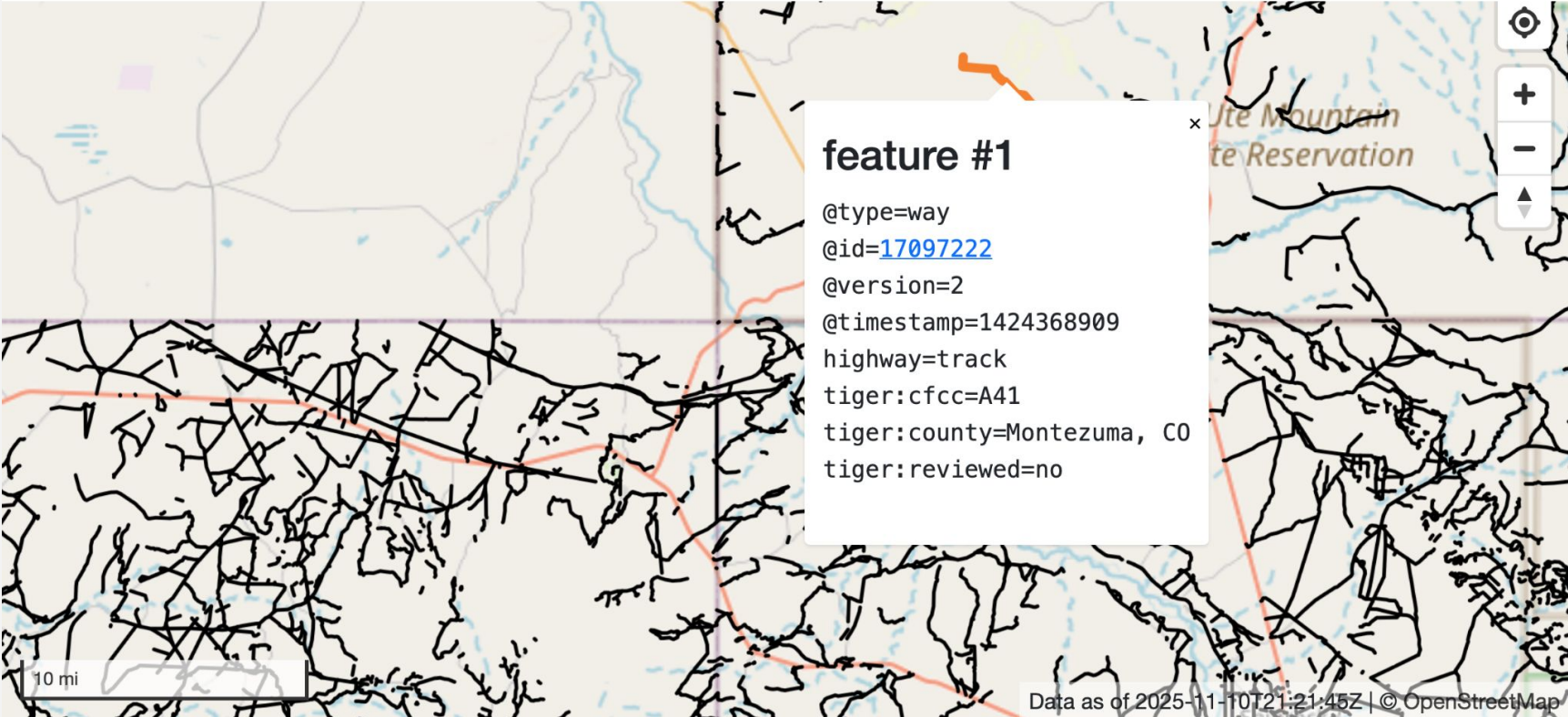
tiger:reviewed=no tag in TIGERMap: <https://watmildon.github.io/TIGERMap/>



tiger:reviewed=no tag in TIGERMap: <https://watmildon.github.io/TIGERMap/>

 TIGERMap

[Edit](#) [View in OSM](#) [Overlays](#) [filter](#) [Filter](#) [Clear](#) [More](#)



feature #1
@type=way
@id=[17097222](#)
@version=2
@timestamp=1424368909
highway=track
tiger:cfcc=A41
tiger:county=Montezuma, CO
tiger:reviewed=no

10 mi

Data as of 2025-11-10T21:21:45Z | © OpenStreetMap

Takeaway: The US map started later than the UK's

2007 vs. 2004

Grew up through different circumstances

The legacy of that initial period remains

The US map is far from “complete”

Experimental mapping patterns are common

What makes OpenStreetMap different in the US?

Why are we like this?

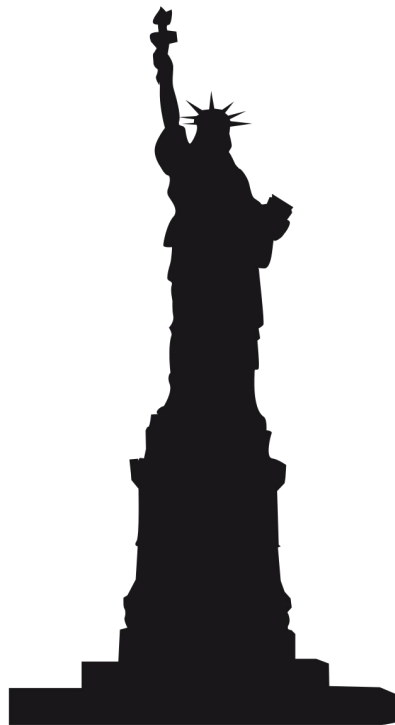
1. Late start



What makes OpenStreetMap different in the US?

Why are we like this?

1. Late start
2. Cultural context and norms



Features with different meanings in US vs. UK

Arcade

Football

Bin

High-speed rail

Campsite

Kindergarten

Caravan

Pavement

Chemist

Public school

Deli

Subway

Faculty

Tram

First floor

Trolley

US-only features(?)



[CC 0 PeterCooperJr](#)



[CC BY SA 4 Michael Rivera](#)



[CC BY SA 4 Infoqomation](#)

“Does the government own all land in a national park?”



Europe: often no

US: yes

“Are pedestrians allowed on a bike path?”



Europe: typically no
US: typically yes

“Can I get there by walking, cycling, or transit?”



Europe: likely yes

US: good luck lol

Takeaway: All mappers operate in different contexts

Our normal is not someone else's normal

Different places have different mapping needs

“Implied tags” are ambiguous without context

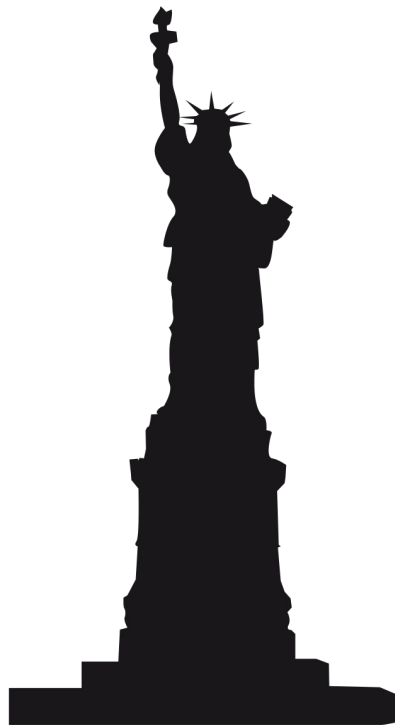
Miscommunications are inevitable

Assume good faith

What makes OpenStreetMap different in the US?

Why are we like this?

1. Late start
2. Cultural context and norms



What makes OpenStreetMap different in the US?

Why are we like this?

1. Late start
2. Cultural context and norms
3. Low density of mappers





Europe

10.2 million km²

745 million people

—

72.9/km²



United States

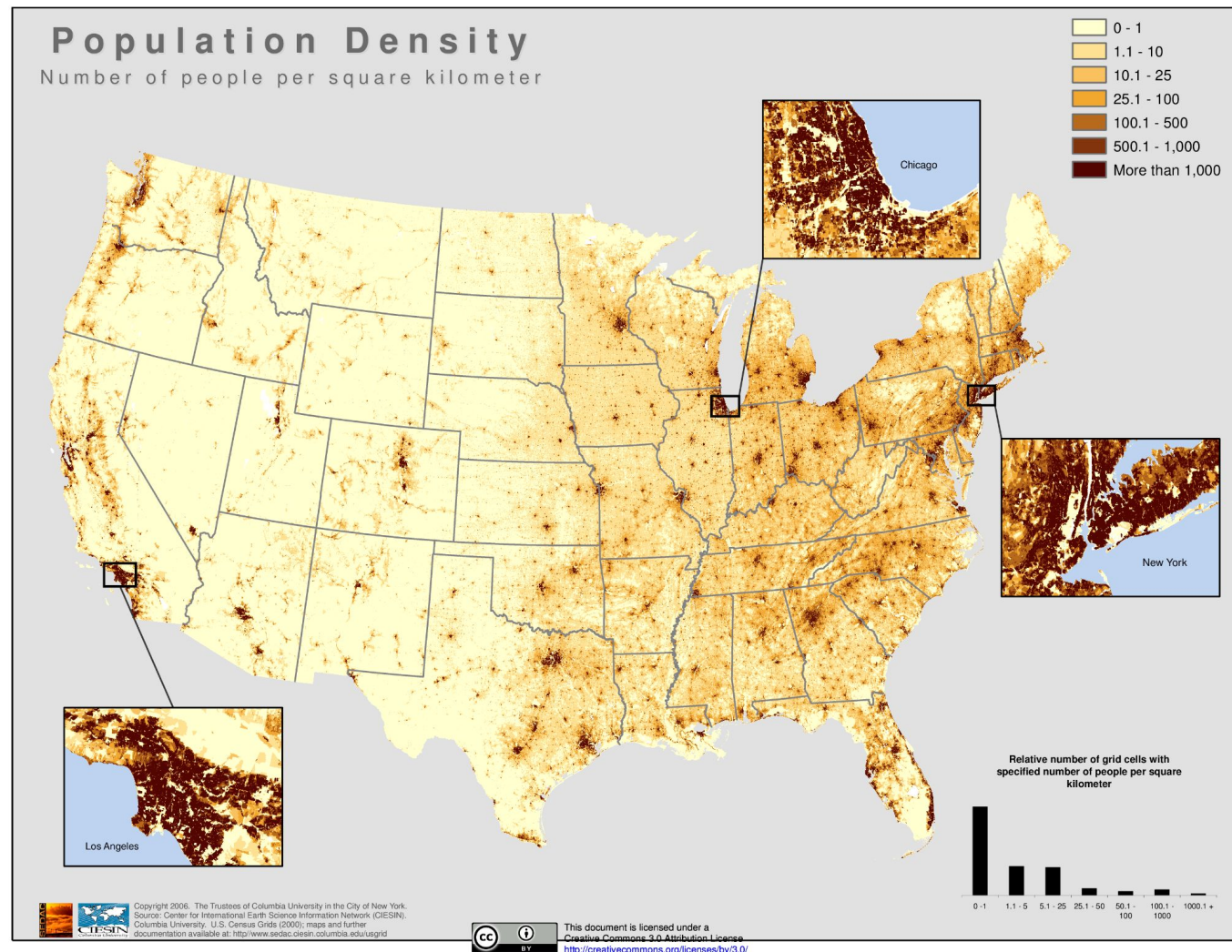
9.8 million km²

340 million people

—

37.2/km²

US population
is unevenly
distributed





[CC BY SA 4 zanygenius](#) (2438 m)



[CC BY SA 2 brewbooks](#)

(161 km)

OSM stats by country

Nov. 2024 – Nov. 2025

Source: <https://stats.now.ohsome.org>

Germany



40,635

Contributors



20,966,197

Total Edits



757,290

Δ Buildings



44,706

Δ km of Roads

France



22,942

Contributors



16,693,209

Total Edits



257,533

Δ Buildings



151,350

Δ km of Roads

United Kingdom



12,539

Contributors



14,673,558

Total Edits



1,710,990

Δ Buildings



27,814

Δ km of Roads

United States



37,154

Contributors



36,644,289

Total Edits



6,133,524

Δ Buildings



885,822

Δ km of Roads

Density of OSM contributors

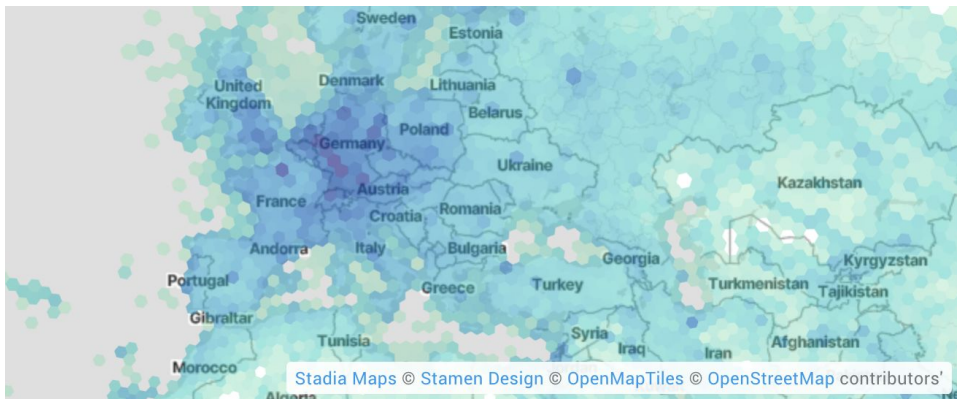
Nov. 2024 – Nov. 2025

Source: <https://stats.now.ohsome.org>

Germany

9 km²/user

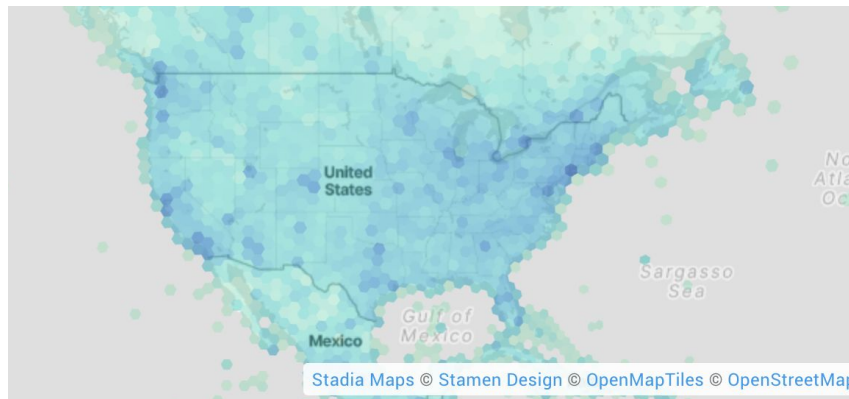
515 edits/user



United States

265 km²/user

986 edits/user



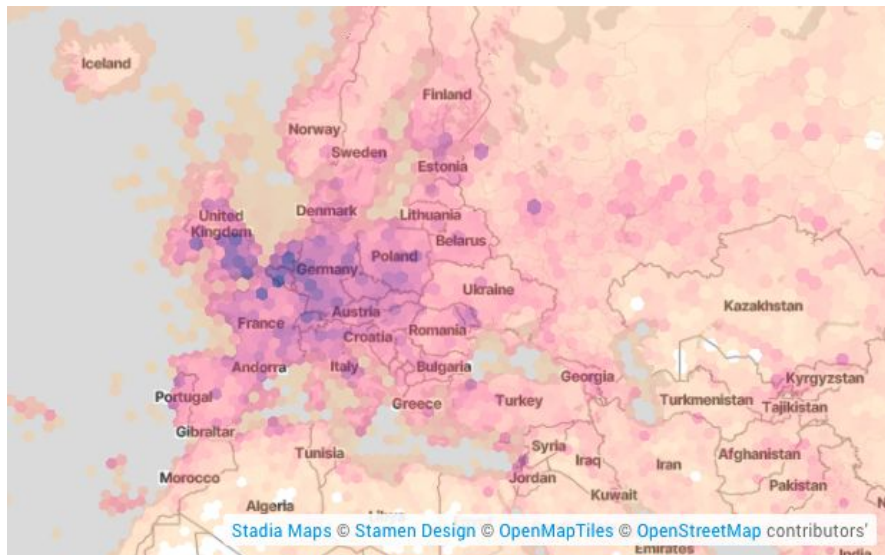
Density of OSM edits

Nov. 2024 – Nov. 2025

Source: <https://stats.now.ohsome.org>

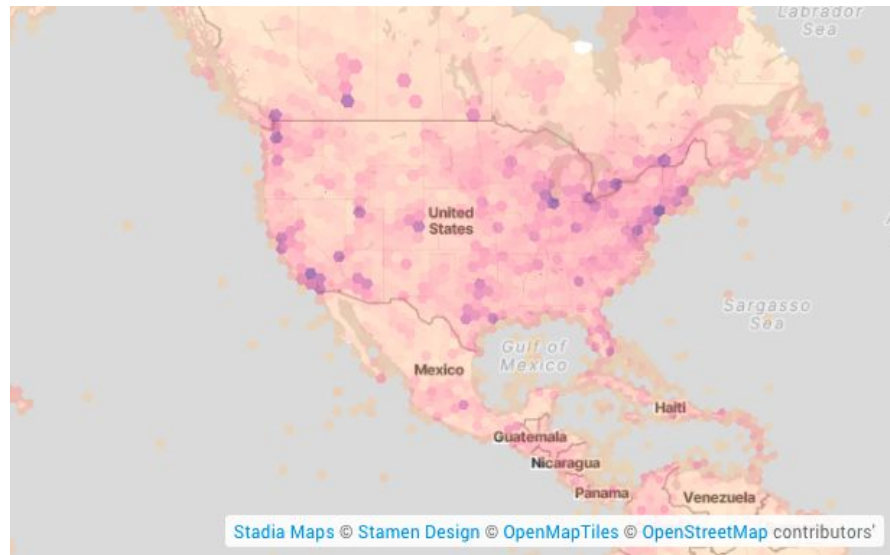
Germany

59 edits/km²



United States

3.7 edits/km²



Incentivizing small town mapping with a Mastodon bot

<https://en.osm.town/@SmallTownUSA>



UnmappedSmallTownUSA

@SmallTownUSA@en.osm.town

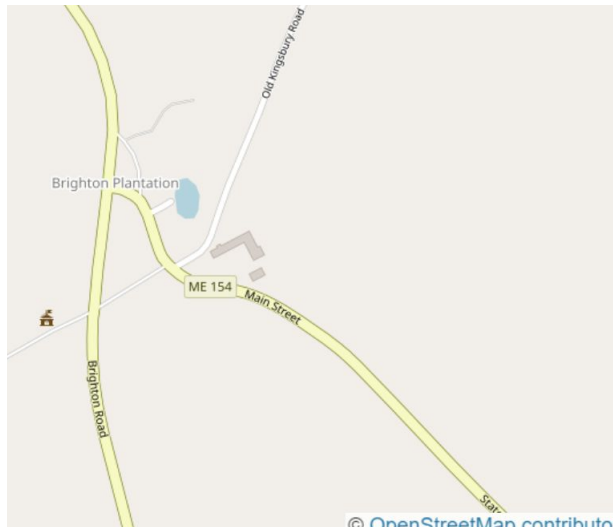
Brighton Plantation, Maine seems like it could use some mapping!

Population: 62

Building count: 6

Roads to review: 2

Map link: openstreetmap.org/#map=16/45.0...
#OpenStreetMap



Kai



@kmpoppe@nerdculture.de

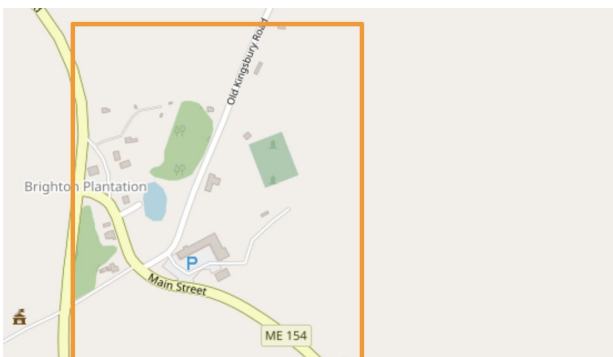
@SmallTownUSA openstreetmap.org/changeset/17... 🤖



OpenStreetMap

Changeset: 172765112

OpenStreetMap is a map of the world, created by people like you and free to use



Non-US mappers mapping in the US

Saturday, February 1st ▾



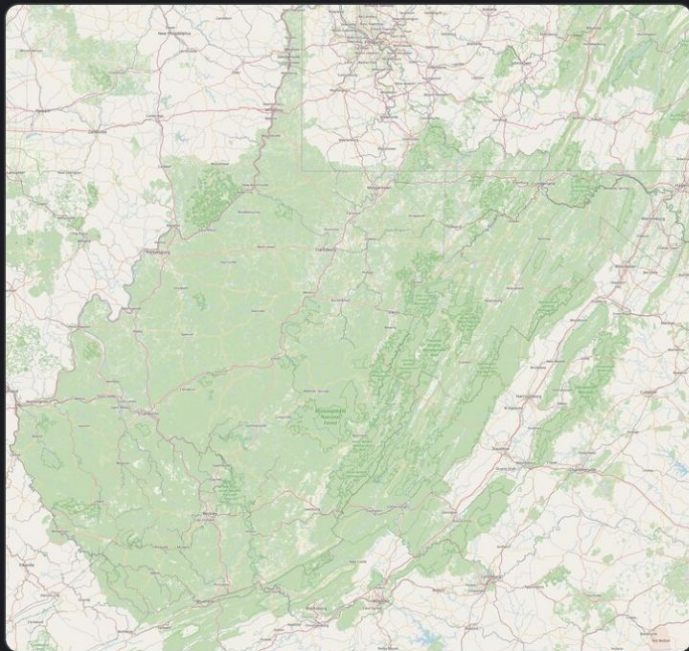
Attila Kun 7:31 PM

The Journey Has Ended. I finished mapping West Virginia's forest land cover.

so from tomorrow I'll be doing PA! 😊

and yes, tomorrow is Groundhog Day, don't forget, so actually PA will be a current topic 😄 (edited)

map (7).jpg ▾



Takeaway: The US has a low density of mappers

The average mapper is making edits in a larger area

Many areas have no active local mappers

Greater reliance on other types of mapping

- Automated edits

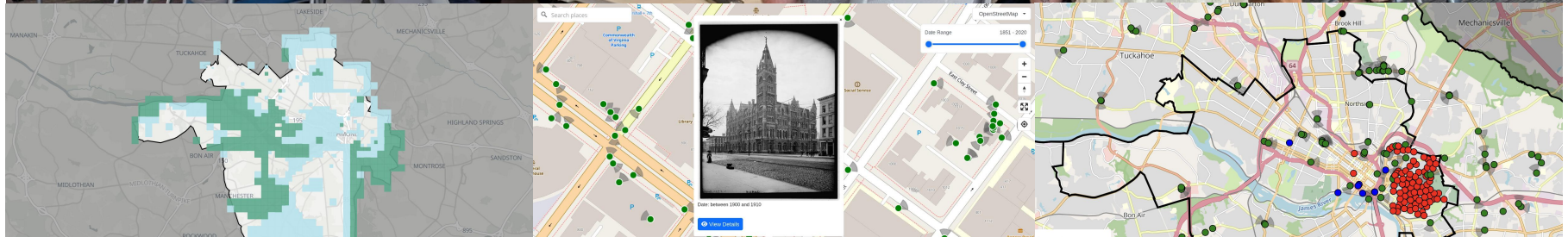
- Tasking

- Completionist/passion projects

Few cities have regular OSM meetups at the moment

Takeaway: The US has a low density of mappers

Counterexample: MapRVA in Richmond, Virginia



What makes OpenStreetMap different in the US?

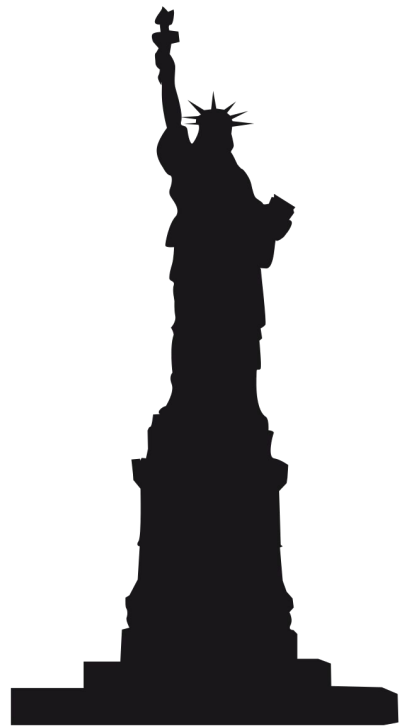
Why are we like this?

1. Late start
2. Cultural context and norms
3. Low density of mappers



What makes OpenStreetMap different in the US?

Why are we like this?



1. Late start
2. Cultural context and norms
3. Low density of mappers
4. Surveying is hard

Traditional European-style mapping

1. Walking survey



[CC BY SA 2 Harry Wood](#)

Traditional European-style mapping

1. Walking survey



[CC BY SA 2 Harry Wood](#)

2. Pub!



[CC BY 2 Alexander Kachkaev](#)

Traditional European-style mapping in the US???

1. Walking survey?



[CC BY SA 2.5 Ben Schumin](#)

Traditional European-style mapping in the US???

1. Walking survey?



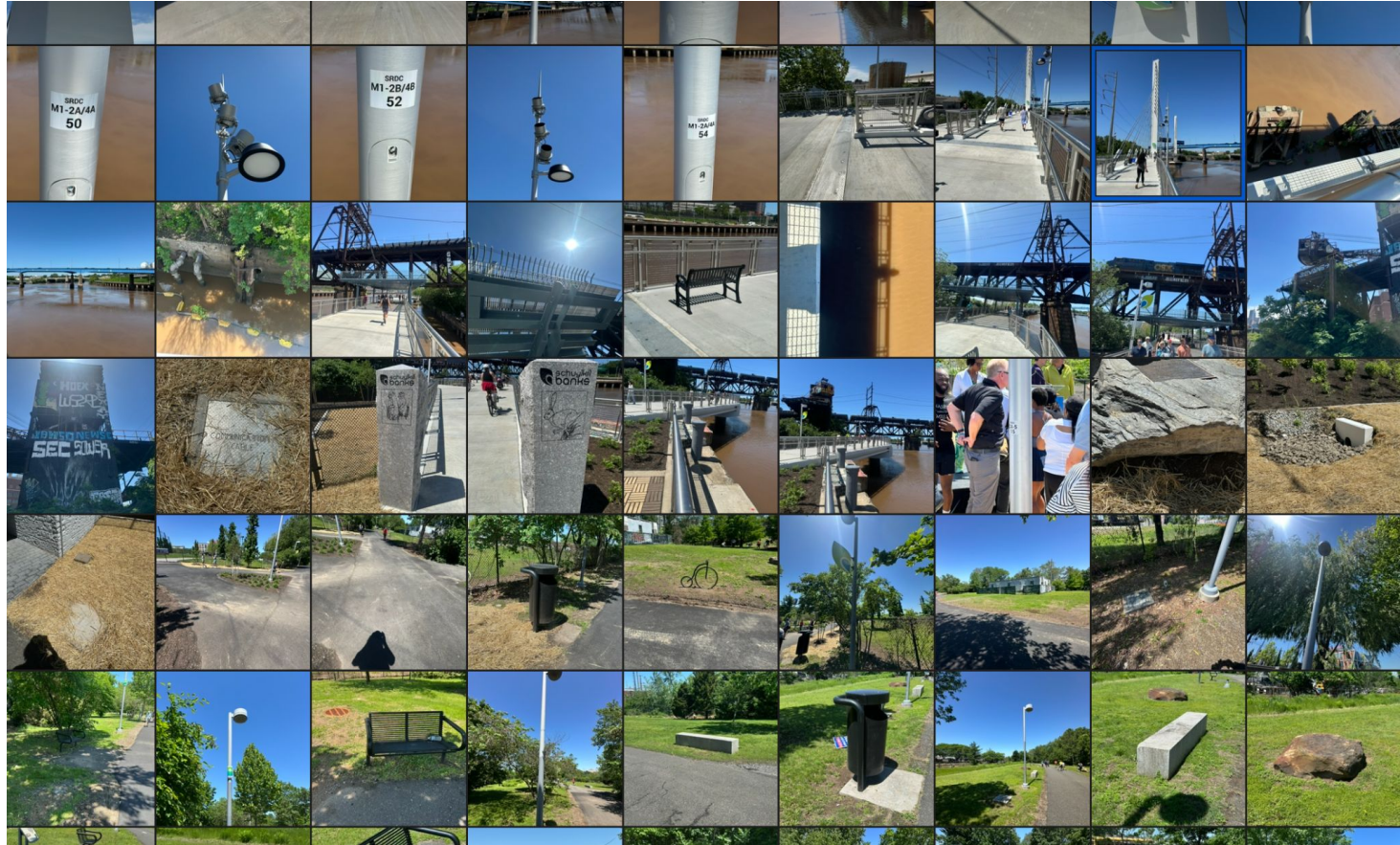
[CC BY SA 2.5 Ben Schumin](#)

2. X



[CC BY SA 4 Sixflashphoto](#)

Surveying is possible, but isn't scalable



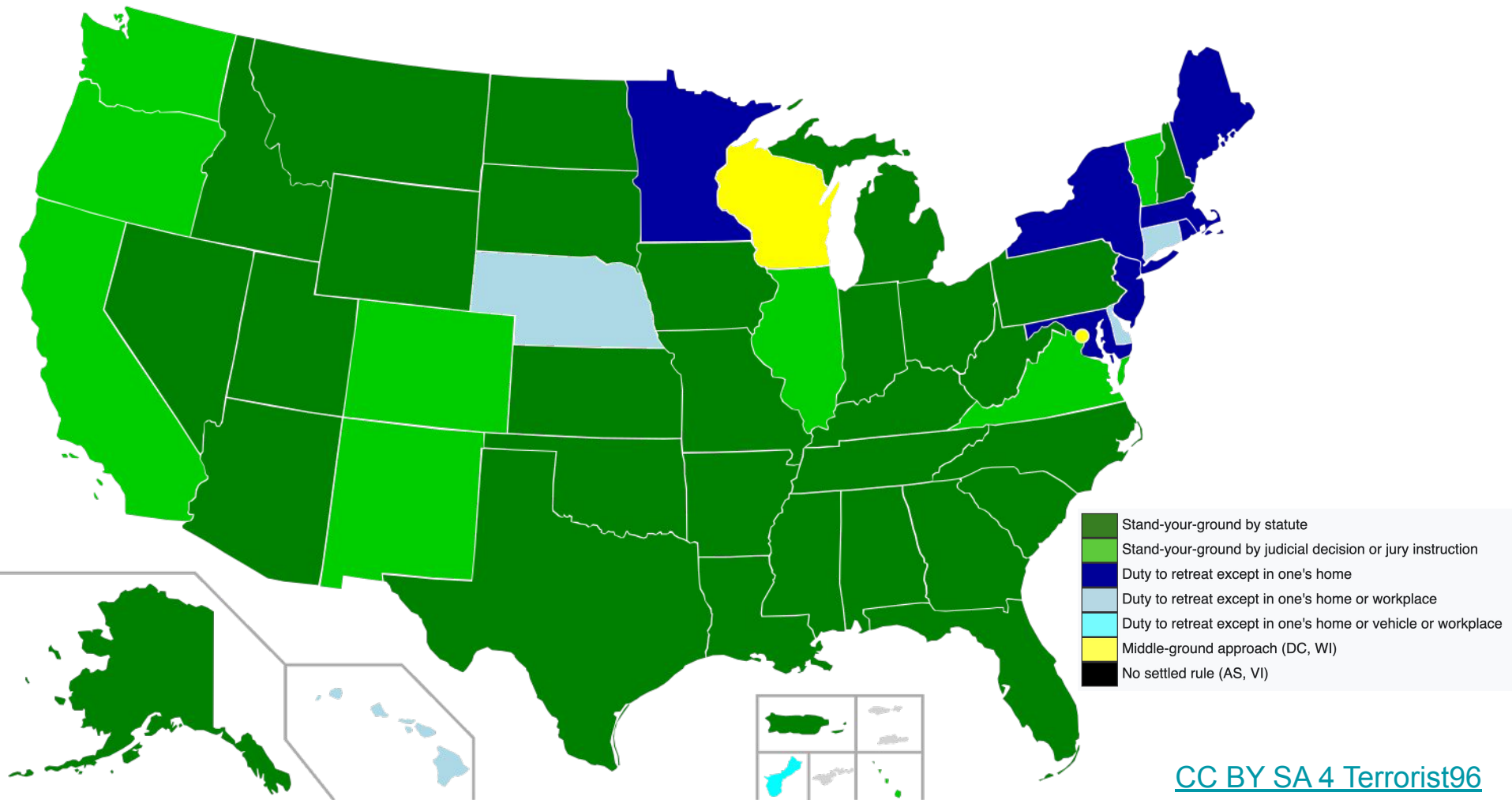
“In any area without lots of pedestrian traffic, a mapper doing a field survey can easily attract menacing stares, or worse, depending on one’s appearance and demeanor. It helps to pretend to be playing Pokémon Go or go out confidently in full corporate regalia.”



[CC BY SA 4 Minh Nguyễn](#)



[CC BY 2 Penny Thompson](#)



Takeaway: Surveying doesn't scale in the US

Too much area to cover

Limited pedestrian infrastructure

Little access to private property — no right to roam

Most rail lines do not carry passenger trains

Americans are highly skeptical of strangers with cameras

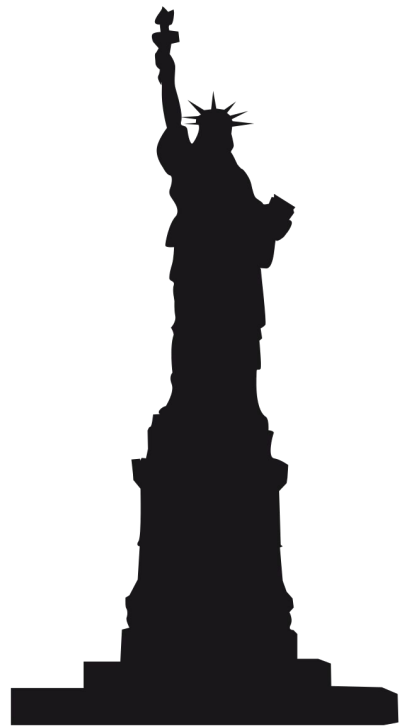
Takeaway: Surveying doesn't scale in the US

Counterexample: Mapillary camera grant program



What makes OpenStreetMap different in the US?

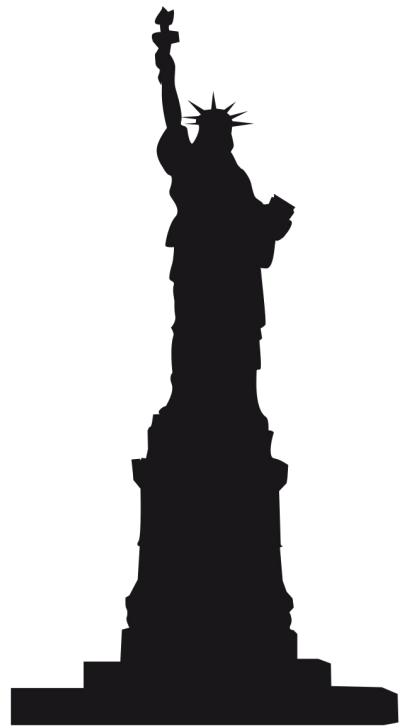
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What makes OpenStreetMap different in the US?

Why are we like this?



1. Late start
2. Cultural context and norms
3. Low density of mappers
4. Surveying is hard
5. Lots of third-party open data

Copyright Act of 1976

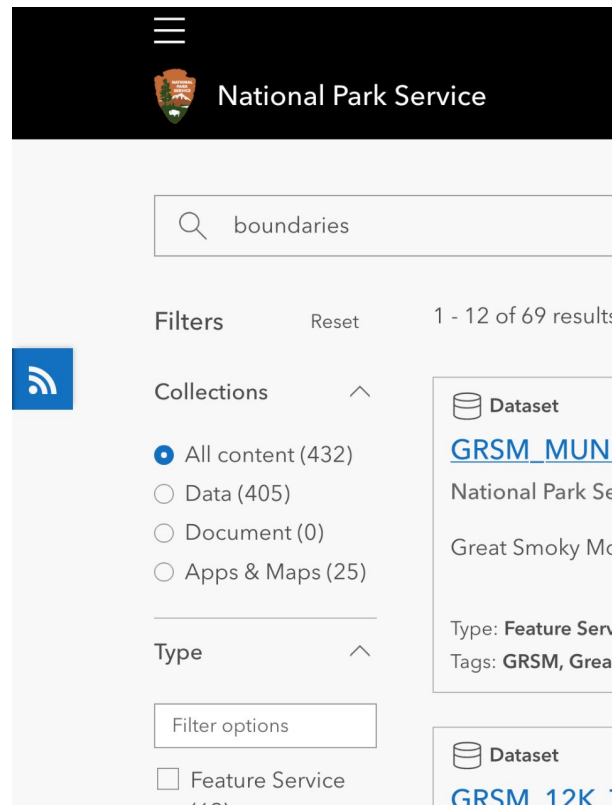
US federal data is *not* protected by copyright

USGS, NPS, USFS, BLM, NASA, NOAA, etc.

Subnational governments exempt

Government contractors exempt

Limited by national security laws



The screenshot shows the National Park Service data portal interface. At the top, there is a black header with the National Park Service logo and name. Below the header, a search bar contains the text "boundaries". To the left of the search bar is a blue square icon with a white RSS symbol. Below the search bar, there is a "Filters" section with a "Reset" link and a count of "1 - 12 of 69 results". The "Collections" section is expanded, showing a list of filter options: "All content (432)" (selected), "Data (405)", "Document (0)", and "Apps & Maps (25)". Below this, the "Type" section is also expanded, showing a "Filter options" button and a checkbox for "Feature Service" which is currently unchecked. On the right side of the page, there are two dataset cards. The first card is titled "Dataset" and "GRSM_MUN", with a description "National Park Service Great Smoky Mountains National Park". The second card is also titled "Dataset" and "GRSM 12K", with a description "National Park Service Great Smoky Mountains National Park".

Feist Publications, Inc. v. Rural Telephone Service Co.

1991 Supreme Court decision about phone books copying each other

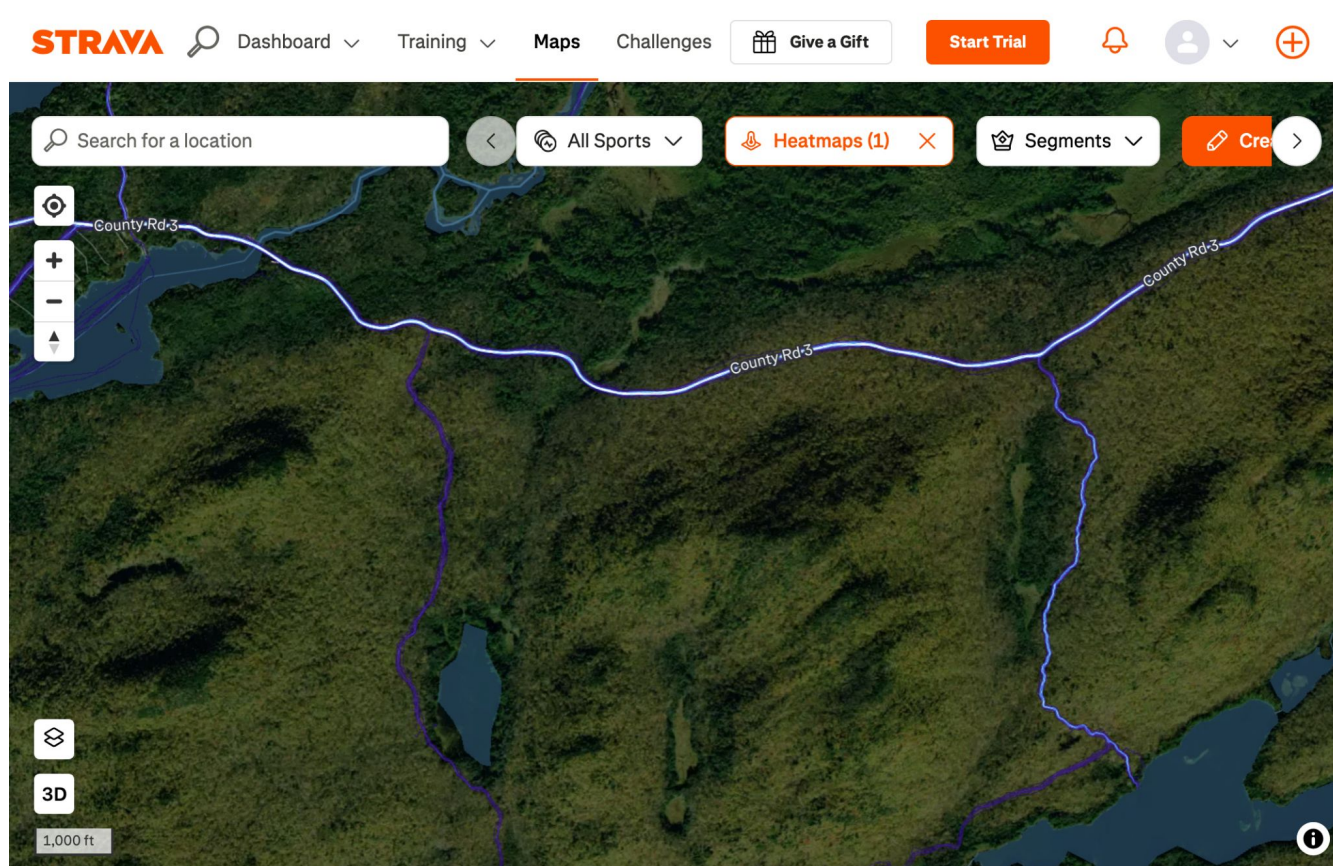
Facts are not protected by copyright

Collections of facts are not protected by copyright

No *sui generis* database rights



Weak privacy laws and expectations



Takeaway: The US has a lot of open geodata

Federal data is compatible with OSM (quality varies)

Subnational data may be compatible on a case-by-case basis

Lots of fair use gray areas

Weak data privacy laws and expectations

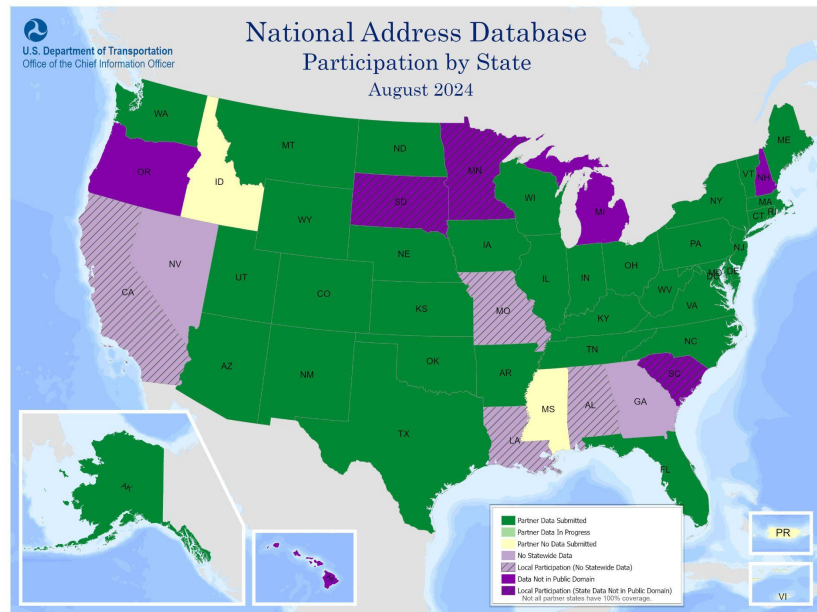
I am not a lawyer

Takeaway: The US has a lot of open geodata

Counterexamples: Sometimes data access is worse

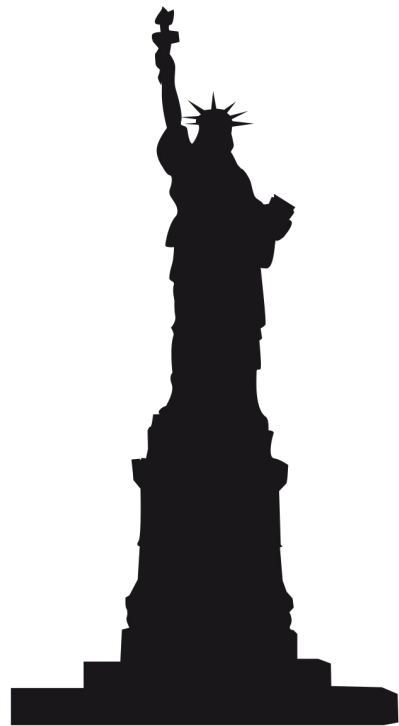
US “national datasets” are often upstreamed from local authorities and may be incomplete

US railroad datasets are proprietary to rail companies



What makes OpenStreetMap different in the US?

Why are we like this?



1. Late start
2. Cultural context and norms
3. Low density of mappers
4. Surveying is hard
5. Lots of third-party open data

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6. (Good) imports are widely accepted



TIGER import is *not* reflective of most US imports

Modern imports are smaller

Require conflation with existing OSM data

Do not require post-import cleanup

Will be reverted otherwise



SPECIAL

Example import: Connecticut buildings/addresses



English Quincylvania Talk Preferences Watchlist Contributions Log out

Page

Discussion

Read

Edit

Edit source



More ▾

Search OpenStreetM

Connecticut/CT Building and Address Import

[< Connecticut](#)

STATUS: Completed

Duration: 28 Feb 2021 - 9 Apr 2022

Current progress: 100%

Note: Additional gaps filling in address points coverage using NAD is still in progr

Participating users: [Mashin](#), [jnighan](#), [roptat](#)

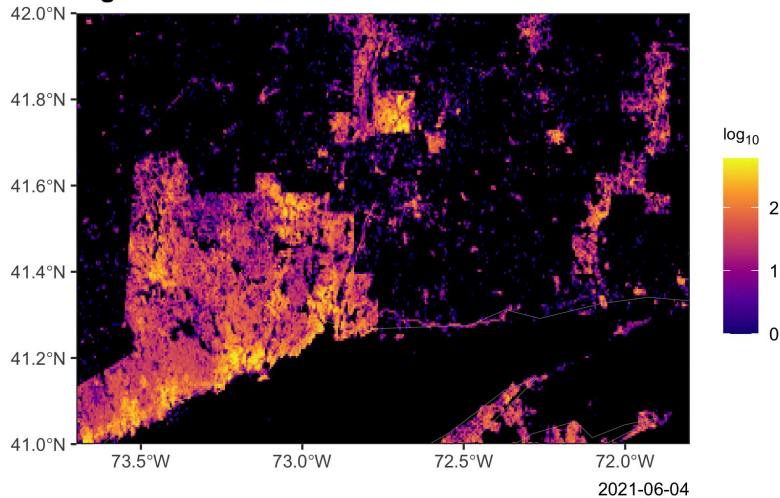
Import account: [CT-import](#)

Changeset comment: #CT-building-address-import (searchable on [osmcha](#))

For comments send PM to OSM account [Mashin](#) or leave a message at [OSMUS](#) [#local-connecticut](#).

Connecticut has still most of its buildings missing in OSM. Building in south-west [imported](#) and the largest cities (New Haven, Hartford, Bridgeport, Middletown, Nc various level of building coverage. Completing the building coverage would allow dedicate their limited time to improvements of businesses locations or road network community was contacted and all responses were positive.

building



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[The map](#)

[Map Features](#)

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[Wiki discussion](#)

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[Permanent link](#)

[Page information](#)

Conflated import workflow: OSM Merge



Source Files

You can get the source data files online from their official sources, I'm only adding the converted data files for review of the conversion process.

[USFS MVUM Highways](#)

The Motor Vehicle Use Map (MVUM) converted to OSM. All abbreviations expanded, access data converted, various other data bugs fixed. All fields not of interest to OSM are deleted.

[USFS MVUM Trails](#)

The off-road vehicle only addition to the MVUM highway data.

[NPS Trails](#)

National Park Service trails. National parks don't have MVUM highways.

[All BLM roads and trails](#)

All BLM datasets merged into one file

[BLM Trails](#)

Bureau of Land Management (BLM) hiking trails

[BLM Roads](#)

BLM public roads

[BLM Off-Road](#)

BLM public trails for Off-Road vehicles, high-clearance usually required

[BLM Limited Off-Road](#)

BLM limited roads for Off-Road vehicles, high-clearance usually required

[USFS Trails](#)

National Forest Service trails.

[US Topo](#)

USGS Topographical Vector Map Data has highways and trails. The data has spotty coverage.

[OSM Highway Data for US](#)

This contains only highway ways and referenced nodes for the entire US extracted from OpenStreetMap. Some bloat, like *tiger:** deleted, and highways not in a national forest or park are dropped.

Photo than

Takeaway: Imports are widely accepted in the US

Still trying to fill major data gaps in OSM

Free datasets are widely available

Can save many thousands of hours of redundant work

Perfect is the enemy of good

What makes OpenStreetMap different in the US?

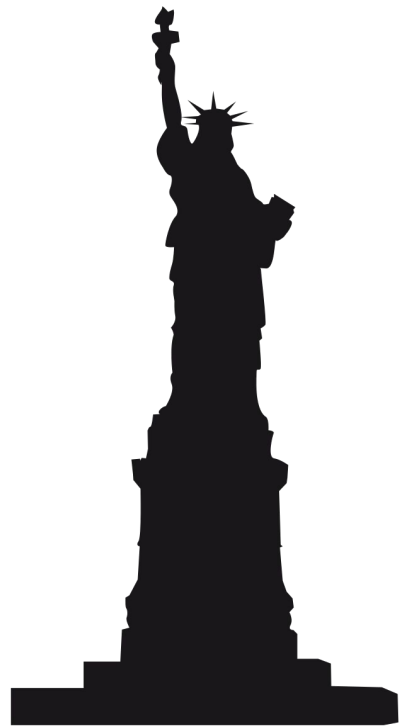
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OpenStreetMap US

Nonprofit organization

Local chapter of OSMF

Elected volunteer board

Employs executive director and paid staff members

Runs State of the Map US

Supports US-based mappers and OSM projects

OSM US Working Groups and Committees

Education Working Group

Government Working Group

Trails Working Group

Pedestrian Working Group

Imagery Working Group

Maintainers Working Group

Collaborators Sync

Governance Committee

Conference Planning Committee

OSM US Pedestrian Working Group

Tagging Guidelines [\[edit | edit source \]](#)

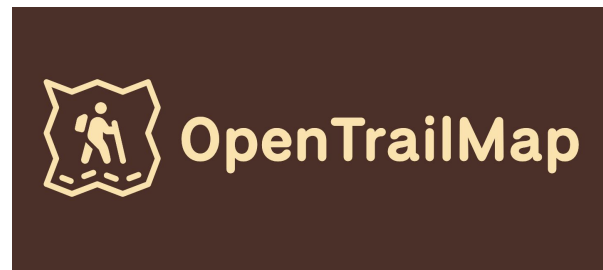
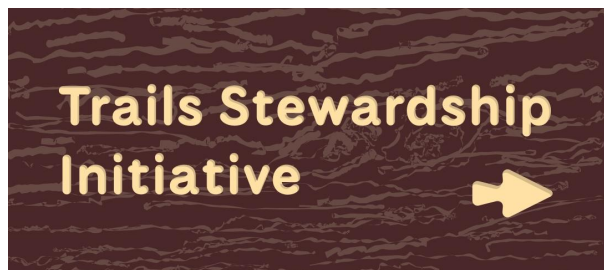
Sidewalks [\[edit | edit source \]](#)

Tag	Element	 Bronze	 Silver	 Gold	 Diamond
<code>highway=footway</code> + <code>footway=sidewalk</code>		Indicates a sidewalk location.			
<code>surface=*</code>			Required in the silver tier, example values include: <code>concrete</code> <code>asphalt</code>		
<code>tactile_paving=*</code>			Is <i>tactile paving</i> present?: <code>yes</code> - Tactile paving is present along the entire way <code>no</code> - Tactile paving is not present along the entire way		
<code>lit=*</code>				Indicate whether the way is lit, examples include: <code>yes</code> , or <code>no</code> , or - any other valid value	
<code>width=*</code>				Specify the width of the sidewalk	
<code>incline=*</code>				Incline along the way (for hilly areas), specified as: <code>up</code> or <code>down</code>	Incline along the way (for hilly areas), specified as a value, example: <code>15%</code>
<code>incline:across=*</code>				Incline across the way	
<code>tactile_paving:colour=*</code>				Specify the tactile paving color.	

Crossings [\[edit | edit source \]](#)

Tag	Element	 Bronze	 Silver	 Gold	 Diamond
-----	---------	--	--	--	---

OSM US projects and programs



OSM US projects and programs



Thematic extracts of OpenStreetMap data in
geoparquet and flatgeobuf formats

(Like Overture but OSM-native)

OSM US projects and programs

Free vector tiles for community projects



OPENSTREETMAP US
TILESERVICE

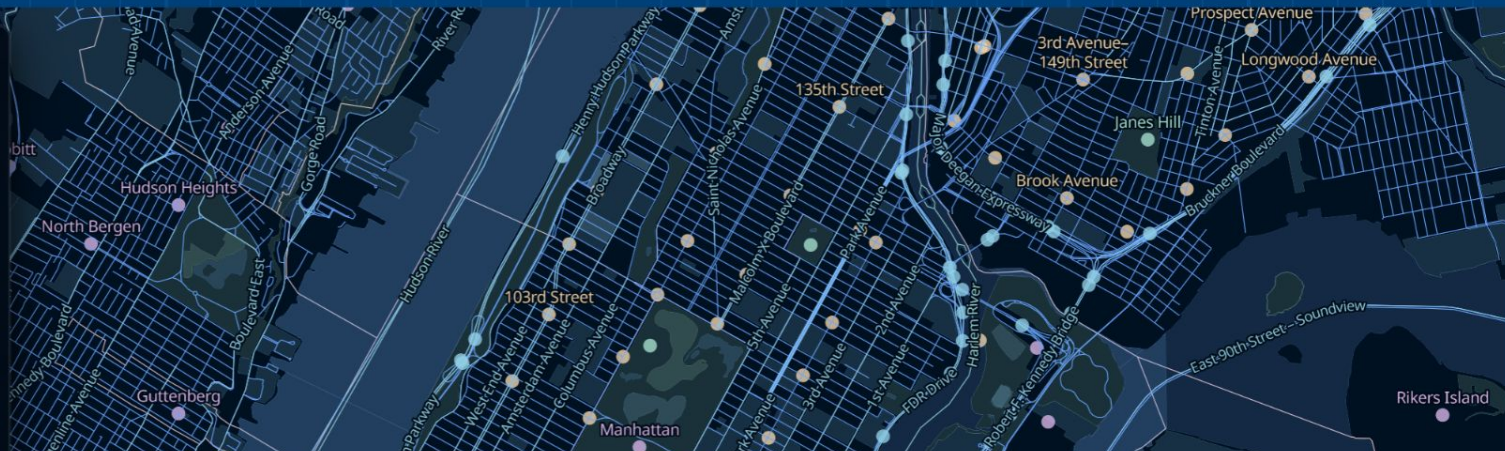
VECTOR RASTER FONTS USAGE POLICY

OPENMAPTILES

<https://tiles.openstreetmap.us/vector/openmaptiles.json>

LAYERS

- ☒ All
- ☒ aerodrome_label
- ☒ aeroway
- ☒ boundary
- ☒ building
- ☒ housenumber
- ☒ landcover
- ☒ landuse
- ☒ mountain_peak
- ☒ park



OSM US projects and programs



Working group, tagging recommendations, and mapping campaigns for US trails

OSM US projects and programs



Institutional support for community-led
OSM projects

Charter Projects of OSM US



MapRoulette

OSMCha



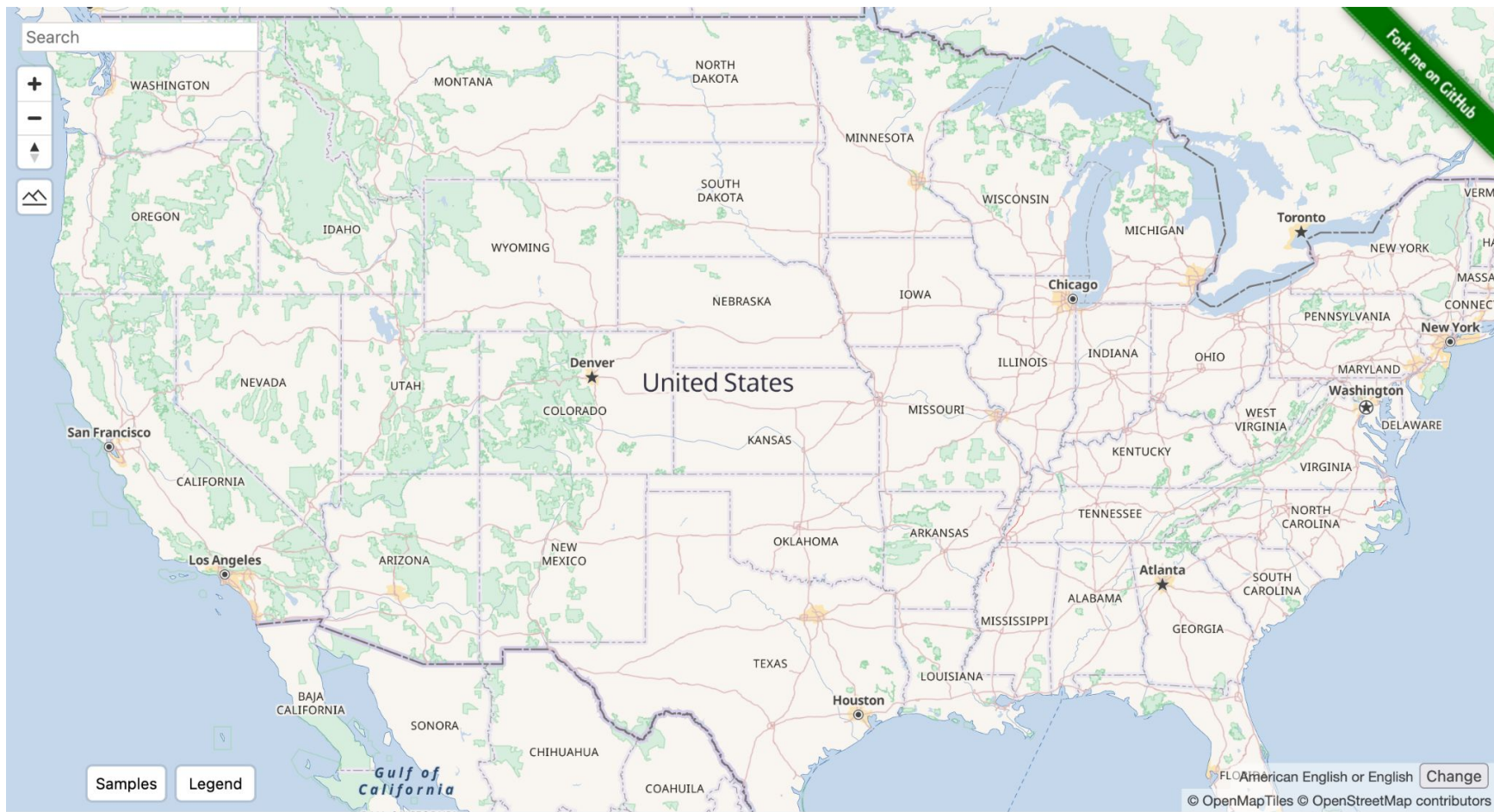
OpenHistoricalMap





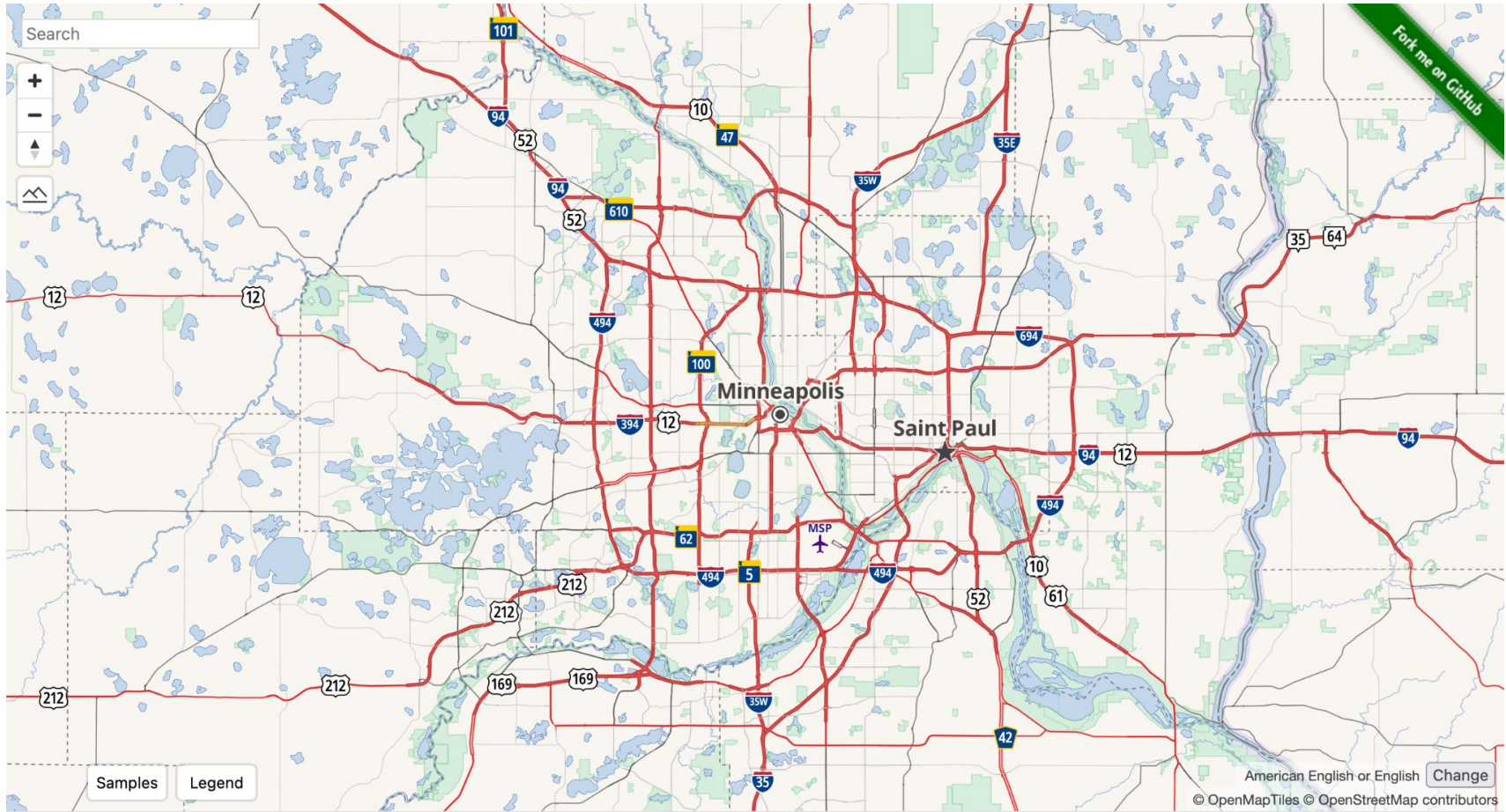
Americana Map Style

<https://americanamap.org>



Americana Map Style

<https://americanamap.org>



Americana Map Style

<https://americanamap.org>



State of the Map US 2026: June 11–13

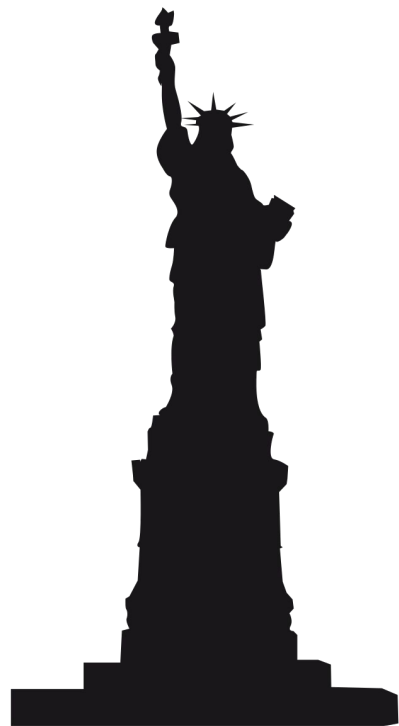


Mapping USA 2026: January 30–31



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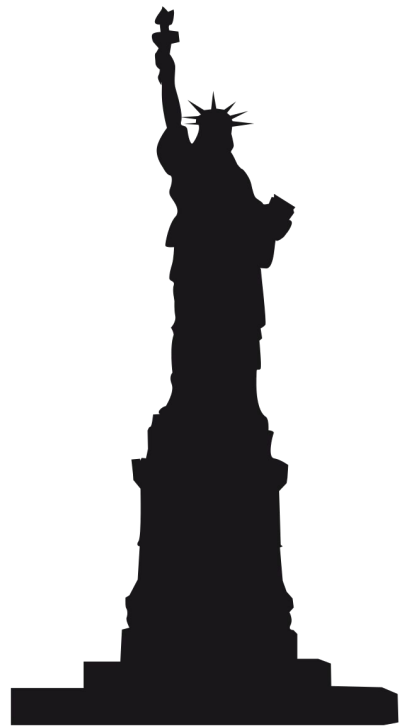
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7. Professionalized support org
8. You tell me!

Thanks!

Quincy Morgan • waysidemapping.org

